

lavish court entertainments the following year—including the stressful production of *L'Arianna*—he suffered some kind of nervous breakdown and for a time withdrew from Mantua. His relations with the Gonzagas never fully recovered. He wrote querulous letters expressing his dissatisfaction with his pay and his status at court. When Francesco Gonzaga succeeded his spendthrift father in 1612, financial cuts were the order of the day. The troublesome Monteverdi and his brother were fired.

Monteverdi then turned his focus on patronage of the Church. In 1610, he published a volume of sacred music, comprising a polyphonic Mass and the Vespers for the Blessed Virgin, a dramatic and complex work in the “modern” style combining solo songs, duets, and instrumental interludes. Dedicated to Pope Paul V, this dazzling volume was virtually a job application, showing how his talents could adapt to religious purposes. In 1613, he was appointed director of music at St. Mark's Basilica in Venice.

Monteverdi appears to have been more content in Venice than at the Mantuan court. He conscientiously executed his duties, writing music for church services and directing the basilica choir. He also continued to write secular music and to explore fresh ways of expressing emotion and linking music to words. His most impressive experiment was a setting of part of Torquato Tasso's epic poem *Jerusalem Liberated*. First performed at a private palace in Venice in 1624, *Il combattimento di Tancredi e Clorinda* is considered the first oratorio and included the first use of *pizzicato*—the strings imitating striking swords.

Monteverdi took holy orders in 1632, but never ruled out a